ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Advanced passive and agency

Use passive, middle and impersonal patterns to foreground affected entities while making deliberate choices about agent visibility. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use advanced passive and agency to control responsibility, process focus and institutional distance without obscuring necessary accountability while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use passive, middle and impersonal patterns to foreground affected entities while making deliberate choices about agent visibility.

MODEL

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

receiver/process + passive or middle + optional accountable agent

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main advanced passive and agency patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses control responsibility, process focus and institutional distance without obscuring necessary accountability.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in legal, scientific, bureaucratic and critical analytical writing.

Build meaning before form

Use passive, middle and impersonal patterns to foreground affected entities while making deliberate choices about agent visibility.

What advanced passive and agency communicates

Use passive, middle and impersonal patterns to foreground affected entities while making deliberate choices about agent visibility.

The central purpose is to control responsibility, process focus and institutional distance without obscuring necessary accountability. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.	the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant
Several files got corrupted during the transfer.	an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse
The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.	a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: receiver/process + passive or middle + optional accountable agent. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Agentless passive	receiver + be + participle	The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.
Get-passive	subject + get + participle	Several files got corrupted during the transfer.
Middle construction	entity + active verb + manner	The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant	Agentless passive
an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse	Get-passive
a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent	Middle construction

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in legal, scientific, bureaucratic and critical analytical writing. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
receiver/process	passive or middle	optional accountable agent

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: control responsibility, process focus and institutional distance without obscuring necessary accountability.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits legal, scientific, bureaucratic and critical analytical writing.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Agentless passive	receiver + be + participle	The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.
Get-passive	subject + get + participle	Several files got corrupted during the transfer.
Middle construction	entity + active verb + manner	The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.	the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant
Several files got corrupted during the transfer.	an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse
The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.	a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not suppress the agent when accountability is central to the claim.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Avoid get-passives where a neutral formal process description is required.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not treat a middle construction as an ordinary active event with a hidden specific agent.

01 · PRACTICE STAGE

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant?

OPTIONS The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn. · Several files got corrupted during the transfer. · The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse?

OPTIONS Several files got corrupted during the transfer. · The new material cuts cleanly and stores well. · The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent?

OPTIONS The new material cuts cleanly and stores well. · The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn. · Several files got corrupted during the transfer.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant · an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse · a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “Several files got corrupted during the transfer.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse · a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent · the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent · the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant · an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Agentless passive / Get-passive / Middle construction · Gap 2: the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant / an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse / a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“Several files got corrupted during the transfer.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Get-passive / Middle construction / Agentless passive · Gap 2: an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse / a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent / the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Middle construction / Agentless passive / Get-passive · Gap 2: a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent / the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant / an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant: _____. Choose the model that expresses an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse: _____. Choose the model that expresses a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent: _____. Choose the model built with receiver + be + participle: _____. Choose the model built with subject + get + participle: _____. Choose the model built with entity + active verb + manner: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

Several files got corrupted during the transfer. · The new material cuts cleanly and stores well. · The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The records _____ after authorisation was withdrawn. Several files _____ during the transfer. The new material _____ and stores well. State the full structural pattern for Agentless passive: _____. State the full structural pattern for Get-passive: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Someone deleted the records after withdrawing authorisation.” using the Agentless passive pattern to express the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The transfer corrupted several files.” using the Get-passive pattern to express an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “People can cut and store the material easily.” using the Middle construction pattern to express a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Someone deleted the records after withdrawing authorisation.” using the Agentless passive pattern to express the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Agentless passive to express the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Get-passive to express an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Middle construction to express a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

Agentless passive is the best match because the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant.

A2

Several files got corrupted during the transfer.

Get-passive is the best match because an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse.

A3

The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.

Middle construction is the best match because a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent.

A4

the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant

The Agentless passive pattern communicates the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant.

A5

an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse

The Get-passive pattern communicates an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse.

A6

a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent

The Middle construction pattern communicates a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Agentless passive / the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant

The structure belongs to the Agentless passive pattern. Its communicative purpose is the process or affected entity foregrounded while the agent is unknown or irrelevant.

B2

Get-passive / an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse

The structure belongs to the Get-passive pattern. Its communicative purpose is an event affecting the subject, often unexpected or adverse.

B3

Middle construction / a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent

The structure belongs to the Middle construction pattern. Its communicative purpose is a property of an entity expressed without an overt agent.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

Agentless passive: receiver + be + participle.

C2

Several files got corrupted during the transfer.

Get-passive: subject + get + participle.

C3

The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.

Middle construction: entity + active verb + manner.

C4

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

Agentless passive: receiver + be + participle.

C5

Several files got corrupted during the transfer.

Get-passive: subject + get + participle.

C6

The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.

Middle construction: entity + active verb + manner.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

were deleted

Agentless passive requires “were deleted” in this model. receiver + be + participle.

D2

got corrupted

Get-passive requires “got corrupted” in this model. subject + get + participle.

D3

cuts cleanly

Middle construction requires “cuts cleanly” in this model. entity + active verb + manner.

D4

receiver + be + participle

Agentless passive is built as receiver + be + participle.

D5

subject + get + participle

Get-passive is built as subject + get + participle.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

receiver + be + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended agentless passive effect.

E2

Several files got corrupted during the transfer.

subject + get + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended get-passive effect.

E3

The new material cuts cleanly and stores well.

entity + active verb + manner. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended middle construction effect.

E4

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn.

receiver + be + participle. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended agentless passive effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The records were deleted after authorisation was withdrawn. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses receiver + be + participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

Several files got corrupted during the transfer. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses subject + get + participle accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The new material cuts cleanly and stores well. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses entity + active verb + manner accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____